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What Goes into the GW Hatchet?

"71 Feared Dead as Plane Hits Bridge, Smashes Cars, Plunges into Potomac."[1] (Meyer, 1982). This was the headline title of *The Washington Post* on January 14, 1982. The day after the fatal crash of Air Florid Flight 90. The Boeing 737 collided with the 14th Street Bridge shortly after its takeoff from the Reagan National Airport and crashed into the Potomac River bringing 74 passengers and 5 crews with it, the death toll was 78, 74 from the crashed plane, and 4 were on the bridge when the collision took place.[2] When facing an incident like this, one would consider that the news would be vastly spread and appear in most of the newspapers in several days, the news article from the *Washington Post* on January 14th, 1982, and the news article[3] from the *New York Times* on January 14th somehow gives the viewer a hint that the theory is true. But there's at least one outlier to the theory. That outlier is the *GW Hatchet*. "The editorially and financially independent student newspaper serving The George Washington University community in downtown Washington, D.C."[4]

Surely when viewing the *About Us* page of the *Hatchet*, it is clear that the earliest report date of the incident should be assumed to appear on the *Hatchet* by January 18th, the first

[1] Meyer, L. 71 feared dead as plane hits bridge, smashes cars, plunges into Potomac. Washington Post.

[2] Review of Aircraft Accident Report--Air Florida, Inc., Boeing 737-222, N62AF, Collision with 14th Street Bridge, near Washington National Airport, Washington, D.C., January 13, 1982. 1982. NATIONAL TRANSPORTATION SAFETY BOARD Washington, D. C.

[3] Clines, Francis X. Plane Hits Bridge over the Potomac, 12 Dead, 50 Missing. The New York Time.

[4] "About Us." The GW Hatchet.

Monday after the crash "The Hatchet publishes a print edition on Monday and an email edition every Thursday during the academic year"[5]. But after going through the Hatchet published on January 18th, 1982, and January 25th, 1982, the crash has nowhere to be seen. This raises a question: "What news would be included in GW Hatchet's headline?".

A Brief Glimpse Upon the Publisher and the Newspaper

What needs to be noted in the first place is that trying to find trends in every headline from 1904 to the present day (2023) is a chunk too big to swallow, so only a slice would be examined, this slice is a 22-year long period from 1970 to 1991, which settles in a rough world but still owns some extent of consistency.

When trying to understand the logic lying under the news choices made by GW Hatchet during this period (from the Vietnam War to the end of the Cold War), we need to examine the newspaper itself in the first place. Who decides what goes into the Hatchet, and which group of the population is their main target to aim for?

The GW Hatchet, as their about page clarified, is "the second-oldest continuously published newspaper in the District"[6], and declares its mission as "strive to fairly report news that informs the Foggy Bottom community"[7] and "aspires to serve every member of the GW community, regardless of an individual's race, religion, ethnicity, nationality, sexual orientation, gender, ability or socioeconomic identity"[8]. From this, it could be noted that the GW Hatchet is a platform that delivers a vast variety of information to the GW community. But while being

[5] "About Us." The GW Hatchet.
[6] Ibid
[7] Ibid
[8] Ibid

inclusive, the aim of the newspaper's goal is also clear: to serve the Foggy Bottom community. This is a sign that the GW Hatchet will own a different standard of putting news on the paper from other random newspapers. And we could see one tip of this iceberg from the Air Floria 90 incident.

Back to the case of Air Florida 90, even though the incident is rocking the city, it does not meet the aim of the *Hatchet* -- serving The George Washington University community[9] in the first place. The crash took place on January 13th which was in the homecoming rush of students returning to their school, and the flight was an outbound flight, no casualties were GW students, and the crash took place on the 14th Street Bridge which is still a distance to the foggy bottom. Thus it is acceptable that the Hatchet has not reported the crash. It seems the criteria of news being included in the hatchet was straightforward—related to the GW community, but before reaching a conclusion, more cases should be examined.

A View of the Topic Through Previous Research Article

Training Tomorrow's Journalists: An Analysis of Student Newspaper Content is a research article written by Schmidt, Hans C, and was published in 2014 in the *Pennsylvania Communication Annual*[10]. In Schmidt's article, he first points out that in the early decades of both the 20th and 21st centuries, the career has seen tremendous changes in a vast variety of aspects and the development of technology has led changes to in publishing. In the 21st century case, the major change is the introduction of Internet-based new media, and this would cause a

[9] "About Us." The GW Hatchet.

[10] Schmidt, Hans C. 2014. Training Tomorrow's Journalists: An Analysis of Student Newspaper Content. Pennsylvania Communication Annual 70 (1): 11–40.

rise of new runners and the complexity of modern journalism highlights the ever-increasing importance of quality journalism schools"[11]. Then Schmidt points out that not only does the student newspaper provide a ground that journalism students can "hone their skills in a hands-on environment"[12] (Schmidt 2014, 13). Then Schmidt wanted to get a better view of what skills the journalism students are developing during their practice in the student newspaper, so he went to look into an investigation that "involved a content analysis of six of the nation's top student newspapers and a survey of student newspaper staff members across the country"[13] (Schmidt ABSTRACT FROM AUTHOR). What he found is several trends.

First, the student paper "Heavy Emphasis Placed on Sports Reporting; Other Topics Neglected"[14], by Schmidt said that even though the sports topic is related to the central role in campus life, it nevertheless would make other stories be neglected.

Second, "Frequently Apolitical"[15], Schmidt points out this is an "alarming" problem since the student would lack experience in writing about political topics, which would make them vulnerable or lack skills in reporting the political topic.

Third, in "Health Issues Largely Ignored"[16], Schmidt found that the number of articles devoted to health-related topics is "extremely low", and this would cause the students who read the newspaper "and who may not receive all of the highly relevant information that could affect their well-being." Quoted by Schmidt.

Fourth, "Limited Sourcing of Articles[17]. Schmidt found that the student newspaper cited

[11] Schmidt, Hans C. Training Tomorrow's Journalists, 12
[12] Ibid,13
[13] Schmidt, Hans C. Abstract, GW Libraries
[14] Schmidt, Hans C. Training Tomorrow's Journalists, 22
[15] Ibid, 22
[16] Ibid, 23
[17] Ibid, 24

primary sources more than others, and a large number of articles were based on interviews with peers, Schmidt claims this could cause students to gain less experience when dealing with individuals in positions of power. Also, the data suggested “more male sources were cited than female sources in campus newspapers by a ratio of nearly 2-1” which raises the question of “whether journalism education programs are adequately encouraging students to seek out a diverse group of perspectives and avoid reinforcing gender-role stereotypes in their reporting.”

In General, Schmidt’s view on student newspapers is like he wrote in his Abstract from Author “Results demonstrate that student journalists cover certain topics frequently, neglect other topics, and use limited sources.” By the end, in the conclusion part, Schmidt points out that while serving the community, the student newspaper should consider finding a balance that could give the students who majored in journalism better practice before they enter the career.

Constructing an Investigation—What Does the Hatchet Include

From the brief view of the GW Hatchet itself, it shows that GW Hatchet intends not to include events that have little to no relation to its audience—The Foggy Bottom Community, but there are still questions that remain. What Topic Does the GW Hatchet include in their newspaper? Or, What Topic Does the GW Hatchet considers that the Foggy Bottom Community Really Needs? To what extent does the pattern Schmidt found in his research could apply to the GW Hatchet?

To find the specific trend of the logic behind the choices, a short investigation was constructed. The investigation was based on gathering the Headlines “above the fold” from

Hatchet that were published in September from 1970 to 1991[18]. After gathering the information and the database was constructed, the headlines would be separated into different groups according to their topics.

Specification:

Why Choosing Headlines or Specific News "**Above the Fold**" instead of Other Pages of the Newspaper:

To answer this question, the definition of "**Above the Fold**" should be introduced. "**Above the fold** is the upper half of the front page of a newspaper or tabloid where an important news story or photograph is often located. Papers are often displayed to customers folded so that only the top half of the front page is visible. Thus, an item that is "above the fold" may be one that the editors feel will entice people to buy the paper"(Wikipedia). Even though this trend may have shifted away when the internet social media was developed, this trend would still be presented solidly from the 1970s to the 1990s. Thus the **Above the Fold** part of the newspaper may magnify the hidden trend. (PS: Single photographs with a line of description would be included).

The Choice of the period the Investigation would be looking into:

The choice to build the database from the Hatchet in this specific period is because in this period, 1970 to 1991, the world was facing drastic changes, so there could be more variation of topics through the period. Also, the period has its boundary set in September 1991, on the eve of the collapse of the Soviet Union—An event that was so powerful that it reshaped so many things, including the media. So stepping on the brake before the timeline reaches that

[18] Information was gathered from the George Washington University Libraries Internet Archive

critical event could largely protect the mere trend that may exist under the Iron Curtain.

The Choice of September over other months:

The reason for choosing September over other months as the source is that September is the first month of a school year and right after a 3-month long holiday which means since the Hatchet is a student newspaper, there usually would be a 3-month gap without any major Hatchet publish, this means that the news the Hatchet publisher need to select to put on their headlines would be piled up, so with a "news pool" that is likely larger than any other months in a year and a limited slot available, I believe the data gathered here would reflect the basic logic of news choice of the Hatchet publisher better than any other months.

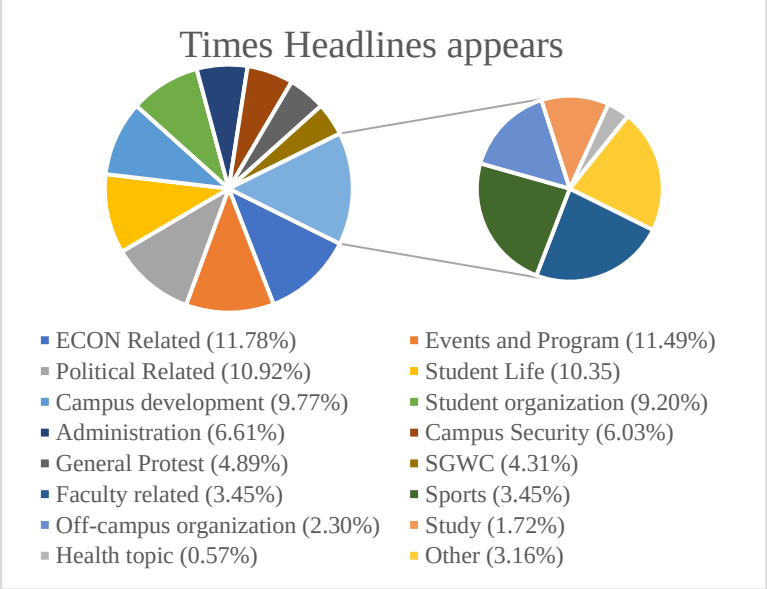
A brief explanation of the categories:

The headlines would be categorized into these categories.

Political Related; **ECON Related** topic(Related to economics and finance); **Events and Program** topic, this is the topic that all on-campus special events and special program GW offers goes into; **Campus developmen**t; **Campus Security; Administration**; **Faculty-related; General Protest** topic, all protest-related articles would be placed here; **Student Life; Sport; Study; Student organization; Off-campus organization**: Not solely focused on off-campus organization but the events that an off-campus organization was highly involved; **SGWC**: Sound from the George Washington Community: This category contains some claims or research findings that students of faculties found or the response to another essay published previously (like a letter to the editor in some extent) and was published on the Hatchet; **Health Issue**; **Other** topics.

Result

After examining 348 headlines, the data shows that Economic topic stands in the top position and owns 41 headlines related to it and made up 11.78% of the total headlines collected; The "Campus Event and Special Program" topic, Political topic, and Student Life sit closely in the 2nd, 3rd and 4th spots, owning 40(11.49%), 38 (10.92%) and 36(10.35%) appearances; Campus development (34 / 9.77%) and Student Organization(32 / 9.20%) topic sits in the 5th and 6th; GW Administration appears 23 (6.61%) times; Campus Security appears 21 (6.03%) times, Protest related topic appears 17 (4.89%) times; Sound from the GW Community owns 14 (4.02%) mentions; Faculty related topics and Sport topic show 12 (3.45%) times(which hold a huge different from Schmidt's research), Off-campus organization involved events appear 8 (2.30%) times, Study topic own 6(1.72%) appearance, Health issue, being the smallest proportion, owns only 2(0.57%) mentions, and there're 11 (3.16%) events that sit in the "other" group.



As for the pattern of specific topics, the Economic topic was only absent for two years (1977 and 1998) and varies from 1 to 4 through other years; The Political topic stays a relatively stable position around 2 to 3 times per year; other topics stay relatively similar pattern but one

more topic should be point out: Sport. We can see that in contrast to Schmidt's research[19], not only does the Sports topic sit in the last few which have a proportion as small as 3.45%, the sports topic was even fully absent in the first 8 years of the total record(1970~1977). At least, the GW Hatchet doesn't think that sport should appear in the headlines that often.

From the result above and the chart shown at the end of the essay, we can see that Hatchet has a relatively stable choice of topics since lead 6 does not differ a huge amount. What's happening in Foggy Bottom, and the changes to the campus were the main focus and we can see the trend that the GW Hatchet is leaning its choice toward the news that was related to the campus.

Discussion of Schmidt's Research Article

When comparing to Schmidt's article, I can see connections that both he and my research share. The most obvious is that both his research and mine found the student newspaper or in my case, the GW Hatchet seldomly report Health issues. In fact, only two were considered as reports related to Health Issues found through the 348 headlines collected. One of them is *Depression: a common affliction*[20] published on Sep.15, 1980, and the other is *Herpes… Disease alarms GW officials*[21] published on Sep.09, 1982. That was only 0.57% of the total 348 headlines, which made it firmly sit in the last place in the list (**others** not included).

But even though both Schmidt's research article and my research shows that report on Health Issue is rare in student newspaper/Hatchet, I found that in the GW Hatchet, the amount of report

[19] Schmidt, Hans C. Training Tomorrow's Journalists

[20] Hatchet Staff 1980, Depression: a common affliction, GW Hatchet (Source from GW Libraries- Internet Archive)

[21] Virginia Kirk, Herpes… Disease alarms GW officials, GW Hatchet (Source from GW Libraries- Internet Archive)

on political issues and sports tells a different story to his research. First, the political issues. From the graph at the end of the essay, we can see that the political topic sits in third place of all 15 categories and owns 10.92% of the total 348 headlines recorded, and if we count the General Protest into the political topic (+4.89%), the political topic could sit in the top of the list owning a 15.81% of the total record, at least from my research so far, the GW Hatchet is not being as "Apolitical" as Schmidt states in his article. A possible reason that this happens could point to the unique location the George Washington University itself. The University sits in the West wing of DC, neighboring tons of government facilities and the White House is just a few blocks away. This creates an environment in which students are surrounded by a political environment. Compared to a random university that built its campus in a suburban, the students there would more likely gain no awareness of any protest which usually happens around government buildings. So the raise on politically related topics may not work when facing a variety of locations on campus and the best way I could imagine that one could practice on political reports could be to open specific courses that practice that, or increase practice on this topic.

I think that Schmidt owns a point concerning the student who is majoring in journalism and works for the student newspaper, and the four-problem student newspaper could be adjusted by raising and lowering the balance of each content. But as the GW Hatchet's About Us page stated, the newspaper is focused on a certain community, so being the newspaper directly aimed toward a certain community, in this case, the Foggy Bottom community, it's better to stay the same as presenting information this community concern more about.

Limitation

When looking into the research project, the major limitation above all is time. Because this limitation exists, it seems impossible to squeeze a total statistic upon everything that appears on every GW Hatchet paper throughout the 22-year-long period. So the compromise I land on is 1st only look into the "Above the Fold" part of the papers.

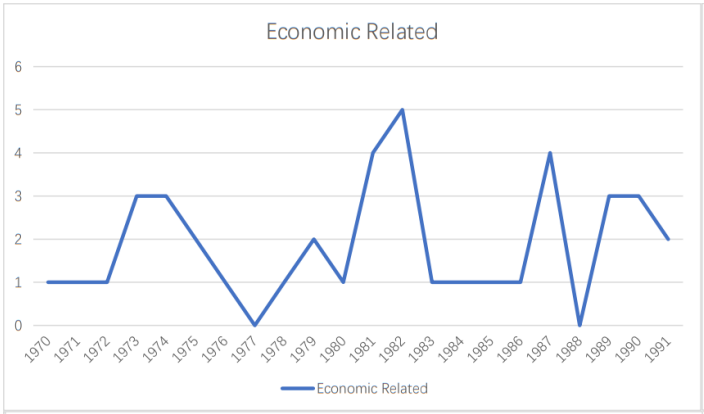
Even though as I mentioned above, the "Above the Fold" news could magnify the possible trend, what was need to admit is that this method has its own bias. The "Above the Fold" part has its own trend of reporting news more than other topics. This could be an alternate explanation for why there were that huge amount of Economic-related and Political topic articles appearing in the database. So further research into my research question should look deeper into other pages of the newspaper.

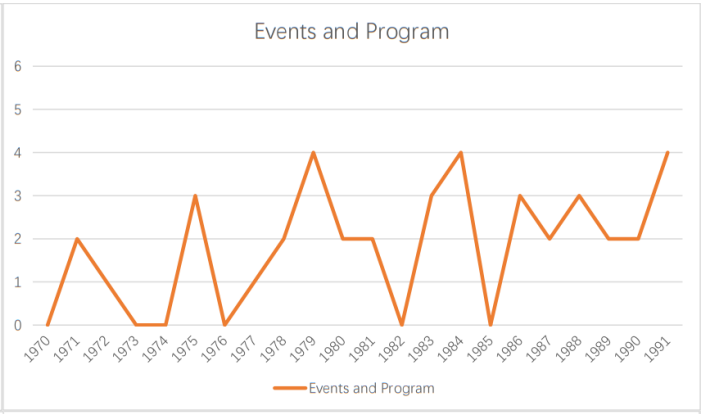
The 2nd compromise was to limit the database solely to every September. It is inevitable that the focus of a newspaper shifts throughout the year, especially student newspapers. September is the first month of the new school year which means that the new policy announcements and campus development appear more in the paper than at other times of the year; November is the election month so the political topics appear more; In May, the topic related with study and final exam's appearance would increase. So further research into my research question will be highly recommended to look into every Hatchet throughout the year, or at least, look into a single year to find a scheme on the shift of topics over time.

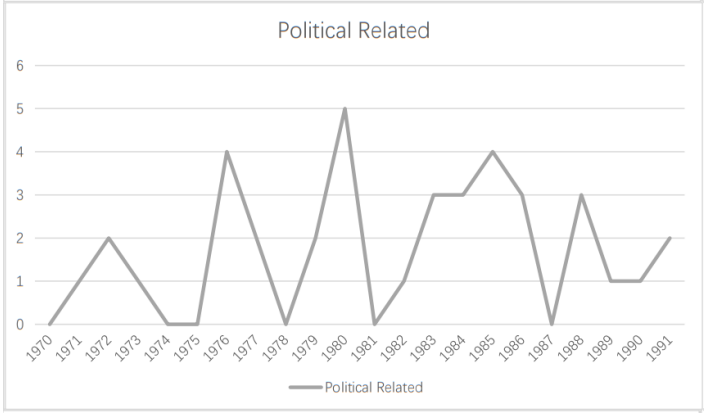
Conclusion

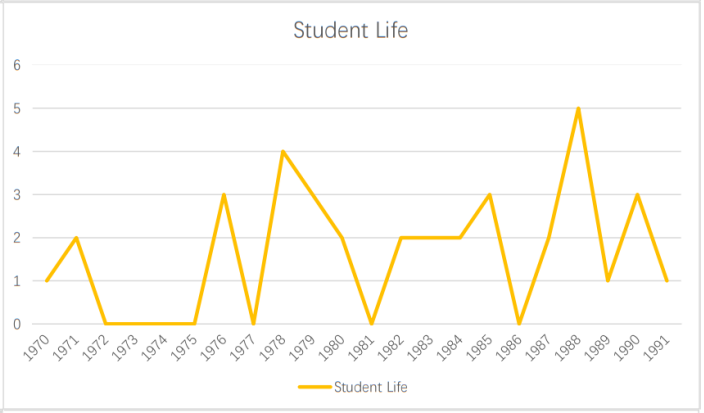
It's clear from the research above, that the trend of topic choosing of the GW Hatchet leaned heavily toward student life, and events that happened on or around campus in the period (from 1970 to 1991) could be seen. This appears that GW Hatchet is following the general trend of the random student newspaper—focus on certain topics and ignore others. However, from the extent of reports on political topics appearing in the Headlines, the GW Hatchet still stands in a spot that differs from other student newspapers.

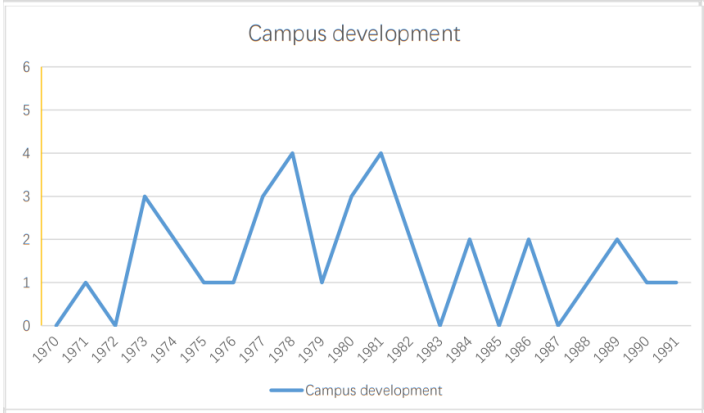
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ECON Related	11.78%	41
Events and Program	11.49%	40
Political Related	10.92%	38
Student Life	10.35%	36
Campus development	9.77%	34
Student organization	9.20%	32
Administration	6.61%	23
Campus Security	6.03%	21
General Protest	4.89%	17
SGWC	4.31%	15
Faculty related	3.45%	12
Sport	3.45%	12
Off-campus organization	2.30%	8
Study	1.72%	6
Health Issue	0.57%	2
Other	3.16%	11
SUM	100%	348

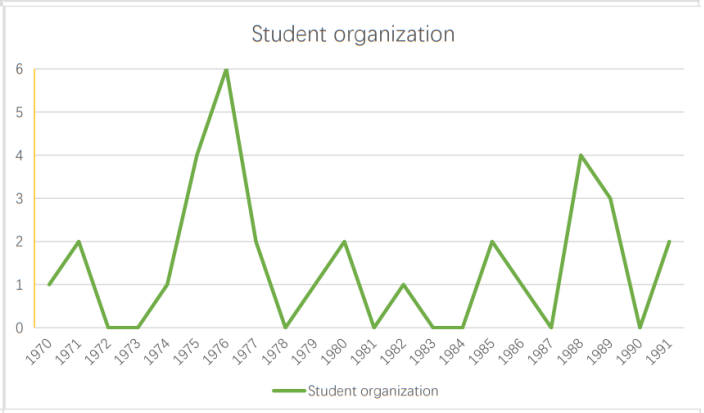

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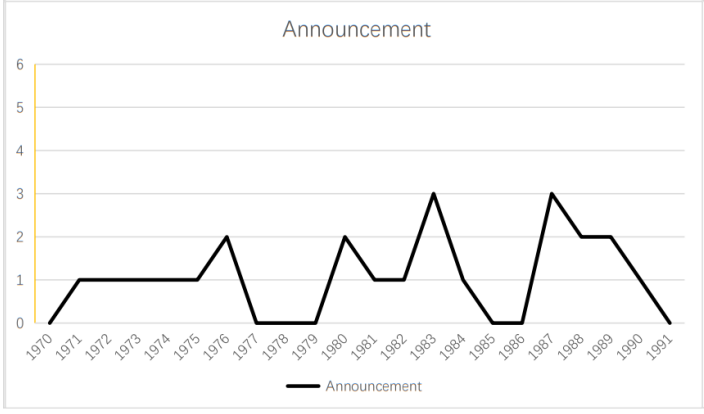

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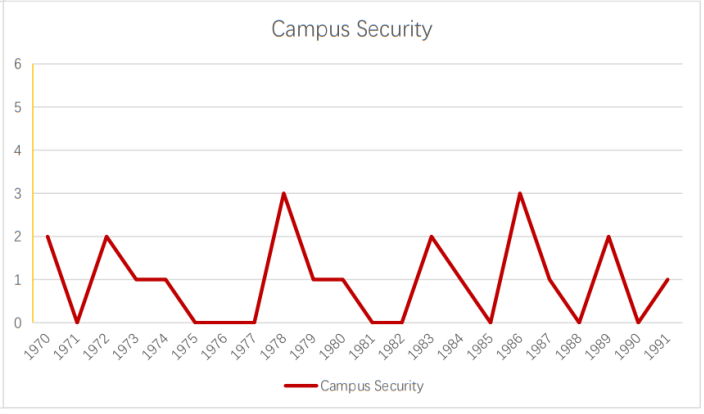

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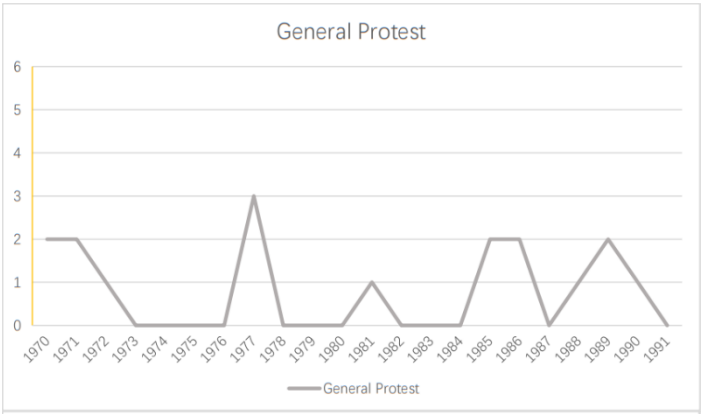

Student Life
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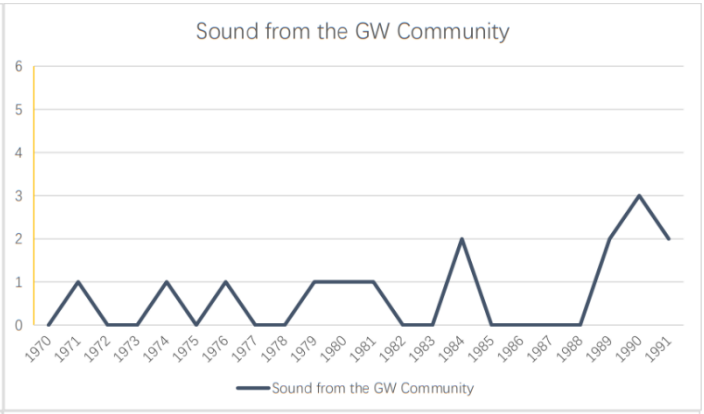

Campus development
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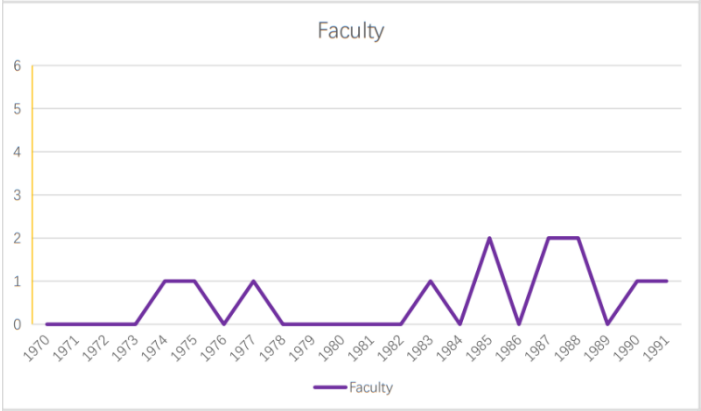

Student organization
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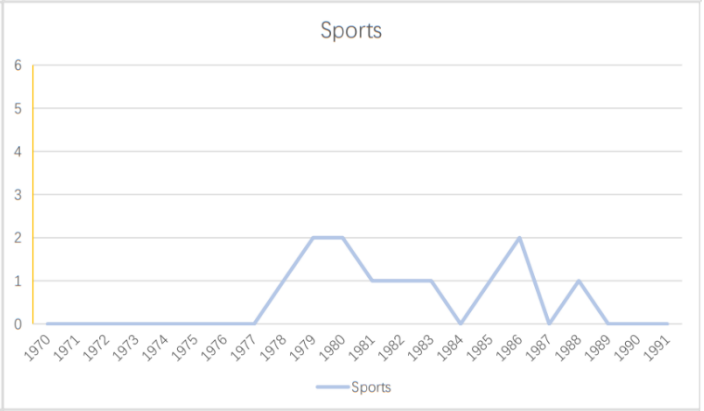

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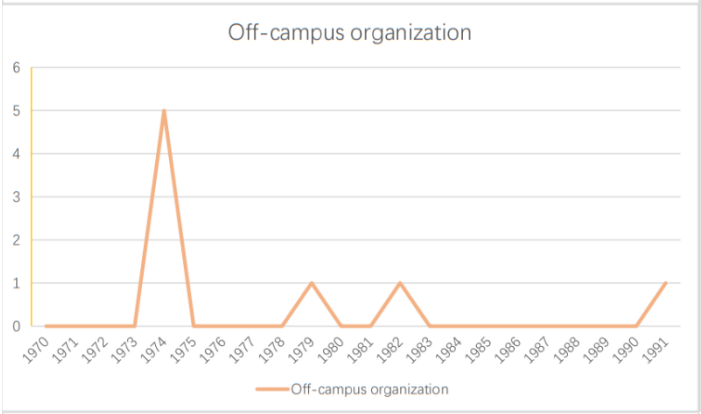

Campus Security
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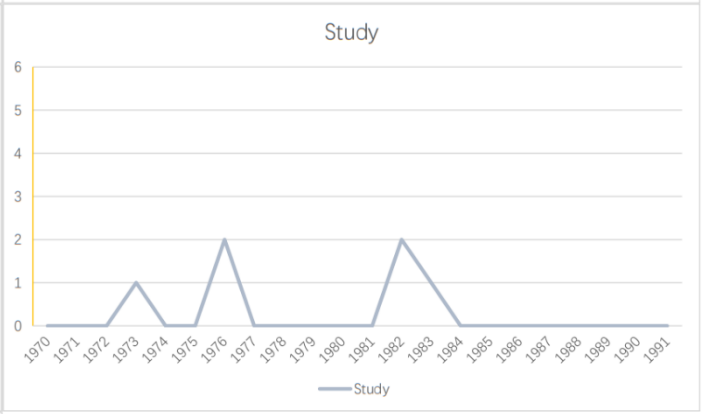

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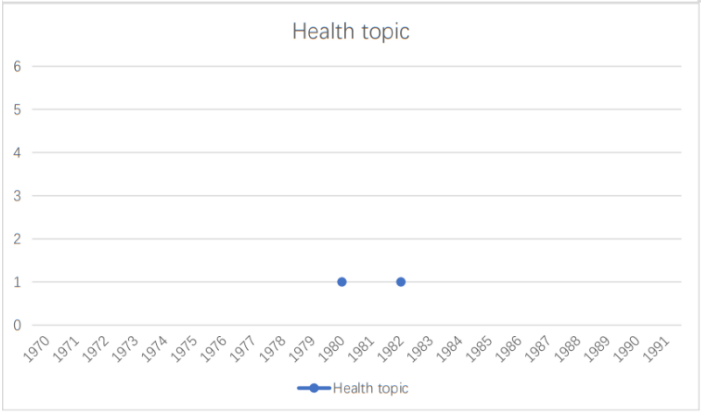

Sound from the GW Community
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Clines, Francis X. *Plane Hits Bridge over the Potomac, 12 Dead, 50 Missing.* The New York Times, January 14, 1982. https://www.nytimes.com/1982/01/14/us/plane-hits-bridge-over-the-potomac-12-dead-50-missing.html.

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The George Washington University Libraries Internet Archive:

https://archive.org/details/gwulibraries?query=Hatchet&sort=date&and%5B%5D=year%3A%5B1976+TO+1990%5D